2.3 Fighting for Better Pay

The phrase "strength in numbers" applies to many situations. During the 1830s and 1840s, American workers in many different industries realized that groups were stronger than individuals.

MAIN IDEA During the mid-1800s, American workers banded together and demanded better, safer labor conditions.

LONG DAYS, HARD WORK

By the early 19th century, factory work had become widespread. Working conditions in most factories, however, were far from ideal.

Most factory workers toiled 10 to 14 hours per day, 6 days a week, no matter if they were elderly or 10 years old. They operated large and dangerous machines without safety gear. Many machine operators were maimed or killed on the job. If workers were injured during their shifts, they received no payment or paid time off to recover, and they often lost their jobs.

At the same time, the costs of living, such as rent and groceries, continually rose. Workers wanted better wages. They also wanted their employers to be held responsible for accidents on the job. Individually, workers knew they had little power to change their working conditions. In the 1820s, workers began to organize **labor unions**, or groups that advocate for workers rights and protections. Together, unionized workers had a much more powerful voice in demanding better pay and safer work environments.



A mill worker poses for a photograph around 1850. Many children worked in the textile mills, including this young girl. Her job may have been to straighten strands of cotton as they moved into the loom.

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Leather Shoes
These leather baby shoes were produced by a Massachusetts shoe factory during the mid-19th century.

Craftsmen such as carpenters and shoemakers also formed organizations called **craft unions**. Craft unions differed from labor unions because most craftsmen did not work in factories, and they had learned a specialized skill. However, their objectives were the same: better wages and working conditions.

Labor and craft unions made progress in improving workplace conditions. But then in 1836, an economic depression hit the nation. Within a year, many factory workers and craftsmen were unemployed. Those fortunate enough to have jobs saw their wages cut by almost half. Displaced and underpaid workers were willing to take on whatever work they could find, and factory and shop owners knew it. As the economy struggled, the power of labor and craft unions decreased.

A WIN FOR WORKERS

When the economy improved in the early 1840s, unions reorganized. **Sarah Bagley**, a millworker in Lowell, Massachusetts, led the way for women's labor unions. She and her female coworkers worked up to 14 hours a day for lower wages than their male counterparts. In 1844, they joined together and established the **Lowell Female Labor Reform Association (LFLRA)**.

Bagley gave speeches denouncing her employer for not acknowledging the issues the mill workers faced daily. After she stopped working at the mill, she published stories about her experiences. Some politicians disliked her honesty and her critical view of mill owners. But her efforts improved the lives of women in the workforce.

Under the leadership of Bagley, the LFLRA appealed to the Massachusetts legislature to enact laws for shorter workdays. The legislature refused to confront mill owners, who agreed to shorten the workday to 13 hours only after public opinion pressured them into doing so in 1847. The LFLRA continued to advocate for shorter workdays. In 1853, mill owners cut the workday to 11 hours.

The actions of the LFLRA inspired other unions in the Northeast. In 1860, a shoe manufacturer in Massachusetts refused the shoemaker unions' request for wage increases. The shoemakers fought back by organizing a strike, or work stoppage. The workers walked out of the factory in protest. Their bold action encouraged similar strikes across New England. Ultimately, 20,000 shoemakers in 25 towns participated. As a result, most of the employers met the unions' demands. The successful strike emboldened the unions, which grew in strength and numbers and soon began to organize on a national level. Even so, Massachusetts did not pass a 10-hour workday law until 1874.

HISTORICAL THINKING

1. **READING CHECK** Why did factory workers and craftsmen form unions?
2. **SYNTHESIZE** Describe how and why the power of labor unions diminished in the 1830s.
3. **MAKE GENERALIZATIONS** What was work life like for 19th-century laborers?

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